

WHO IS THE LEADER?

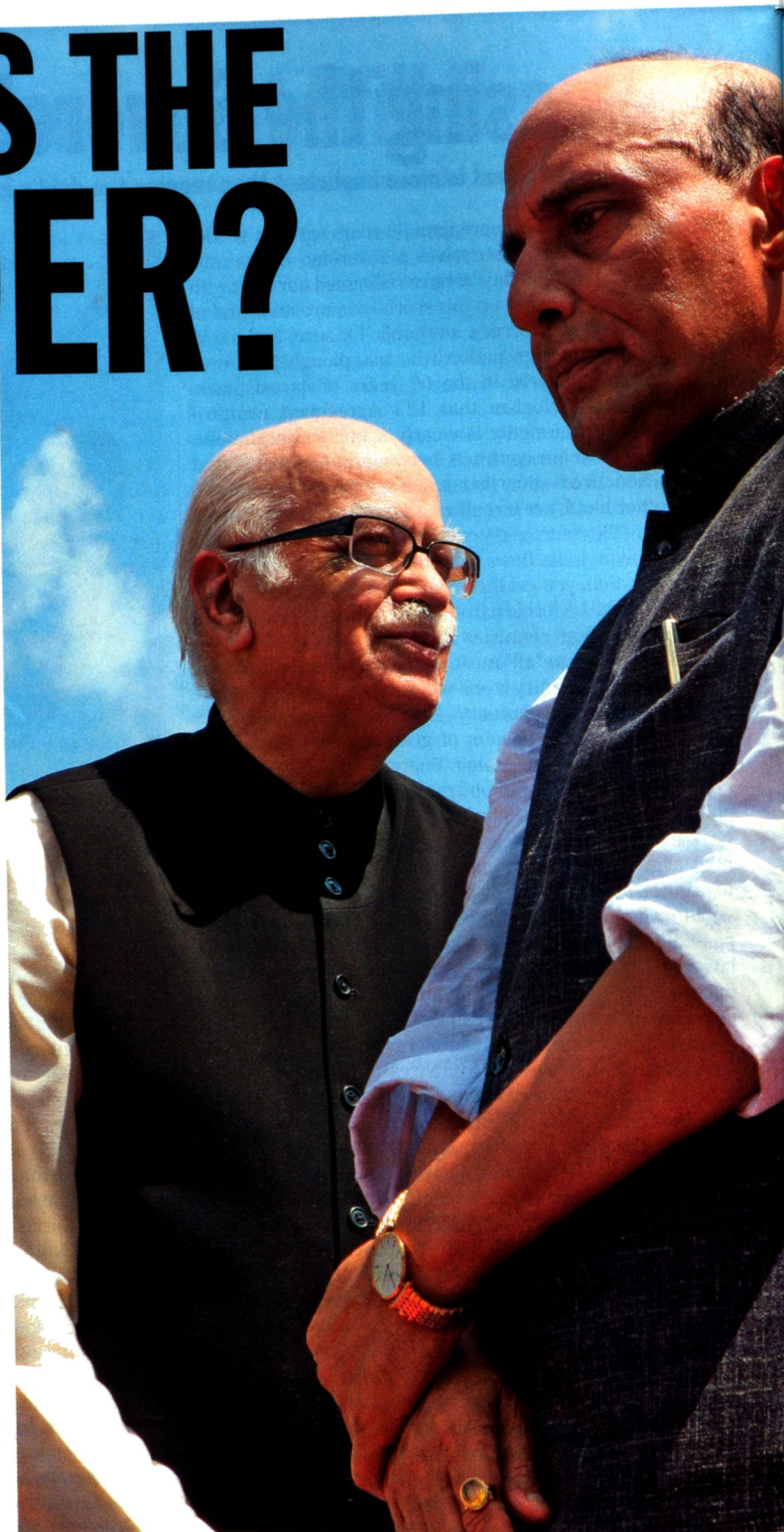
Advani's unilateral views on the nuclear deal, divergent to the official stand, are symptomatic of a larger battle within the BJP for control of the party

■ By Priya Sahgal

At 79, most people live out lives that are predictable and passé. Lal Krishna Advani is an exception. Two years ago, the former deputy prime minister, who had been brought back as the BJP president following the May 2004 poll debacle, was forced to quit as party chief after his controversial remarks on Mohammed Ali Jinnah while on a visit to Pakistan. His departure was not widely mourned, though gradually he managed to climb back to the centre stage in the BJP. Last week, he sprung yet another surprise on his colleagues by articulating views on the Indo-US nuclear agreement that were not in consonance with the official party line, drafted by the party's core group, of which Advani is a vital part. It was a statement that truly put the nuclear cat among the BJP pigeons.

So was the party softening on the nuclear standoff? Was Advani reflecting the view of BJP or was it his own? Many questions, but few had the answers, least of all party president Rajnath Singh. It was shades of the Jinnah crisis all over again. Watching the BJP struggle to explain his new line, Advani realised that he had once again been trapped by wrong advice and issued a clarification saying that the decision taken by the party leaders

DIVERSE TACTICS, SAME GOAL:
Advani (left) with Rajnath



ISHAN TANKHA